

CIRCUS



IRCUS IS A ROLEPLAY-FOCUSED NPC SUPPLEMENT FOR 5E THAT PRESENTS A TRAVELING CIRCUS AS A LIVING SOCIAL faction rather than a combat encounter group. Instead of treating carnival performers as background flavor or disposable entertainers, this book expands the concept into a structured troupe of specialists—each with a distinct role, talent, and extraordinary non-combat gift.

The intent of this product is narrative leverage rather than mechanical escalation. These characters are not designed as enemies to defeat but as personalities to interact with, bargain with, learn from, or depend upon. Each member of the circus carries one remarkable talent that makes them valuable in stories: gathering crowds, moving unseen through festival chaos, calming dangerous beasts, predicting consequences, or performing feats that defy ordinary skill.

While most members of the circus can defend themselves if cornered, violence against them is rarely the intended outcome. Their strengths lie in mobility, performance, social manipulation, and practical expertise rather than battlefield lethality. In most settlements the circus is tolerated—or even welcomed—because of the joy, spectacle, and economic activity it brings.

Their operating rhythm is familiar in towns across the world:

- **Arrival.** Wagons roll into town, canvas rises, and lanterns begin to glow.
- **Curiosity.** The barker gathers crowds and rumors begin to spread.
- **Wonder.** Performers amaze audiences with impossible skill, strength, and daring.
- **Connection.** Patrons trade gossip, secrets, and coin beneath striped tents.
- **Departure.** By dawn, the wagons may already be rolling toward the next town.

Every circus is different. Some are wholesome entertainers, others are information brokers, wandering mystics, smugglers, or found families of performers who have chosen the road over roots. Cultural origins are intentionally minimal so that the troupe can fit into nearly any setting.

Use these stat blocks as narrative instruments. A circus might provide refuge, spread rumors, distract authorities, calm dangerous animals, predict dangerous choices, or simply bring a rare night of wonder to a troubled town.

Why the circus came to town—and what secrets travel with it—is yours to decide.

CIRCUS LADDER

Name	Challenge Rating	Description
Carnival Child	0	Quick-footed youth raised under canvas who moves unseen through crowds and festival chaos.
Tentmaster	0	Practical logistics expert who can erect camps, stages, and wagon circles with remarkable speed.
Barker	1/8	Silver-tongued promoter capable of gathering crowds and controlling public attention.
Clown Trickster	1/4	Satirical performer whose ridicule and antics can undermine reputations or distract enemies.
Knife Juggler	1/2	Precision throwing performer capable of impossible accuracy with blades and delicate strikes.
Animal Handler	1	Beast-tamer who calms animals and commands trained companions.
Acrobat	2	Gravity-defying performer who moves effortlessly across ropes, rafters, and narrow surfaces.
Strongman	3	Powerful grappler famed for lifting impossible weights and subduing troublemakers.
Fortune Teller	3	Enigmatic seer whose cryptic readings reveal the consequences of future choices.

BARKER

Medium humanoid (any), any alignment

Armor Class 12

Hit Points 11 (2d8 + 2)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)	16 (+3)

Skills Deception +5, Insight +3, Performance +5, Persuasion +5

Senses passive Perception 11

Languages Common plus two others

Challenge 1/8 (25 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +2

Draw a Crowd. If the barker spends 10 minutes loudly promoting an event in a populated area, a curious crowd gathers unless authorities actively intervene. In tense scenes, the barker can call attention to themselves, turning the area within 20 feet into lightly obscured terrain as onlookers gather and jostle.

Silver Tongue. The barker has advantage on Charisma (Performance) checks made to hold attention and advantage on Charisma (Persuasion) checks made to encourage curiosity or harmless interest.

ACTIONS

Cane. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target.
Hit: 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage.

Pocket Sand (Recharge 6). The barker throws dust, glitter, or sawdust at a creature within 5 feet. The target must succeed on a DC 12 Constitution saving throw or be blinded until the start of the barker's next turn.

- The barker tries to defuse danger with humor, distractions, or by pulling bystanders into the situation.
- Use Draw a Crowd to complicate chases or tense negotiations with curious townsfolk.
- If violence begins, the barker retreats behind the crowd and shouts warnings to the rest of the circus.



CLOWN TRICKSTER

Medium humanoid (any), any alignment

Armor Class 14 (padded costume)

Hit Points 22 (5d8)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)	13 (+1)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)

Skills Acrobatics +5, Deception +4, Insight +3, Performance +4, Sleight of Hand +5, Stealth +5

Senses passive Perception 11

Languages Common plus one other

Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +2

Weaponized Embarrassment (1/Day). If the clown publicly mocks, satirizes, or exposes a creature in front of at least three witnesses, the target must succeed on a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw or suffer disadvantage on Charisma checks made in that settlement for 24 hours. The effect ends early if the target meaningfully repairs its reputation.

Spellcasting. This clown is a 0th-level spellcaster. Its spellcasting ability is Charisma (spell save DC 12)

- **At will:** *vicious mockery*

ACTIONS

Trip Prank. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 3 (1d4 + 3) bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or fall prone.

REACTIONS

Slapstick Evasion. When the clown is hit by an attack it can see, the clown can move up to 10 feet without provoking opportunity attacks.

- The clown rarely escalates violence and prefers humiliation, distraction, or escape.
- In social scenes, Weaponized Embarrassment can undermine nobles, guards, or rivals.
- In combat, the clown uses Vicious Mockery and movement to frustrate enemies rather than defeat them.



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